

new private colleges have been opened and another 18 will be set up in next academic session. A total of 163 general colleges, 93 B.Ed. colleges, 36 nursing colleges and one law university have already been opened in last four years. A Maharshi Panini Sanskrit and Vedic University has been opened at Ujjain for study and research of Sanskrit and Vedic subjects. At the same time, the state government has taken steps to fully safeguard the interests of students. A fees regulatory committee has been constituted by enacting a law. The committee is determining the fees as per quality of facilities in medical, technical and management institutions. This would strike a balance between the interests of the students and the institutions. Madhya Pradesh is one of the few states to have set up fees regulatory committee by enacting a law as per the directive of the Supreme Court.

As part of measures to improve quality of educational new arrangement has been put in place for a continuous direct dialogue between teachers and the administration. IT is being widely used in the functioning of the department. Through the website the directives are issued to all the colleges simultaneously and their implementation is being ensured. During the elections to the students unions all correspondence was conducted by e-mail. A weekly video conferencing is held between senior officers of the department with the principals. This exercise has enabled solution of the pending problems of colleges and it becomes possible to find out the status of implementation of the directives issued by the department. It also saves money and time, which would have otherwise spent on journey by concerning persons. In a unique initiative a series of divisional file disposal and review camps were organized to find out and solve the problems of the teachers and staff of colleges. The principals, additional directors and Mantralaya officers examined and disposed off the long pending cases and issued necessary orders then and there. This has helped solve the problems of college management to a great extent.

The state government has paid special attention to improvement of quality of higher education over the last four years. The Private University Act has been enacted to facilitate establishment of private universities by internationally renowned and reputed educational institutions in the state. A Private University Regulatory Commission has been constituted. This would also enable the institutions to offer courses in tune with the requirements created by industrialization and globalization.

Computer education has been introduced at graduate level to improve their competitiveness in this age of computer and IT. In next six months all the colleges would be networked through computer. This aims at providing the new techniques of education management to colleges. Besides, automation of libraries of 88 colleges is in progress. A scheme is ready to take up another 80 colleges for library automation by end of the current financial year.

Action is also being taken to provide new facilities to the 2 lakh 85 thousand odd college students in the state. The amount of scholarship provided to scheduled caste and scheduled tribe students for research work has been increased from Rs. five thousand to Rs. eight thousand. The books and stationery allowance for these students has also been increased.

A novel Gaon Ki Beti scheme has been implemented to provide higher education facility to meritorious girl students of rural areas. Under this, earlier the highest scoring of the girls of every village passing the XII examination in first division was given a scholarship of Rs. five hundred per month to pursue



further studies. As many as 60,524 girl students have benefited from this over last three years. Now this facility has been extended to all the girls of villages passing XII examination in first division. On the same pattern a Pratibha Kiran scheme has been implemented for talented girls of urban families. A Vikramaditya Scheme has been launched to grant scholarships to students of poor general families to pursue higher studies. As many as 5,433 students have received the scholarship during last two years.

Sincere efforts have been made to link education to employment for which an action plan has been executed. Entrepreneurship development, computer education and environment education have been introduced in the foundation course of the first year of graduation for expansion of IT education and implementation of the Industrial Promotion Policy of the state government. An EDUSAT programme and Virtual Classrooms have also been started. The Higher Education Department has also launched a Swami Vivekanand Career Guidance Scheme to inform the students about career prospects. Career guidance cells and placement cells have been set up in all the colleges. Jobs have been provided to over 1700 students through job fairs organized under the scheme. The state government has paid due attention to development of infrastructure. In last three years buildings have been sanctioned for 65 colleges which do not have their own buildings. Additional rooms, labs and auditoriums have been provided to 85 colleges.

In order to complete teaching work Assistant Professors have been appointed on vacant backlog posts. Principals of postgraduate colleges have been promoted and principals have been appointed in postgraduate colleges. Besides, casual Assistant Professors have been regularized. UGC pay scale has also been granted to the college teachers. It can, thus, be justifiably claimed that successfully facing the challenges Madhya Pradesh is fast moving towards becoming a higher education hub.